

The drive to get kids off social media

送信者: POLITICO Brussels Playbook 受信日時: 2026-07-10 13:51

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Presented by OpenAI By GABRIEL GAVIN GOOD MORNING — I'm Gabriel Gavin, officially declaring the Brussels Bubble summer holiday season open, after a To

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GOOD MORNING — I'm Gabriel Gavin, officially declaring the Brussels Bubble summer holiday season open, after a To Meli barista yesterday called out "see you in September" as I left the coffee shop.

In today's Playbook:

— What if the EU's wealthiest countries just walked away from MFF talks?

— How to screw up the hiring contest for top EU officials.

— Faces in the crowd: Count Binface, Liisa-Ly Pakosta, Dariusz Standerski, Friedrich Merz, Marine Le Pen, Nigel Farage, Agnieszka Bartol, Kyriakos Pierrakakis, Jessica Rosencrantz, Nadia Calviño, Malala Yousafzai, Balazs Ujvari and many more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Week Ender podcast: Sarah talks to Aslı Aydıntaşbaş about the EU's on-again, off-again relationship with Turkey, and journalist John Kampfner about his book "Braver New World."

****A message from OpenAI: Teen safety protections are built into ChatGPT, with tools families can use to adjust features, set time limits, and add safeguards that work for them.****

DRIVING THE DAY

TIME TO LOG OUT: Children and teenagers across the EU could be banned from using social media sites within the next few years under plans being drawn up in Brussels, and European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen is kicking off the push next week.

Starting gun: Von der Leyen will make a short statement about the proposals on Monday. She'll also publicly accept the findings of an expert report she commissioned into the harmful effects of digital platforms on young people, as Eliza Gkritsi and I report this morning .

What will it say? The proposals will contain concrete recommendations about how to limit the harm done by social media, those working on it say, but won't be specific about what should be banned. Yet one of the authors has already contributed to a German analysis published last month that recommended barring under-13s from the likes of Instagram, Facebook and X.

True believer: The report isn't designed to convince von der Leyen, who, as a parent and a medical doctor, is said to be already deeply concerned about the issue. Instead, one EU official said, it's a way to encourage any skeptical national governments to get on board by providing "an evidence base" for the proposed ban. Von der Leyen first hinted at the plan in last year's State of the European Union address.

She's got support: "We've seen that already 14 member states are on board," Poland's Digital Affairs Minister Dariusz Standerski told Playbook. "I believe that we have now a strong majority in favor of those solutions. We've heard from a couple of countries which are not really happy about those proposals — however, I do not see any possible blocking minority right now."

Stark warning: "Children about 6, 7 years — those kids are seeing harmful content: child pornography, bullying and other crimes on the internet," Standerski said, adding that "more than 70 percent of people [in Poland are] supporting a social media ban for children and age verification."

Parental panic: "If you have already said that we are going for a ban and we are looking for a way how to do it, then this [report] is a little bit biased," Estonia's Justice and Digital Affairs Minister Liisa-Ly Pakosta said. It's "perfectly clear that the Commission is interested in a social media ban" and "there is a kind of parental panic behind that," she said.

Living in harmony: But EU countries including France and Poland are already at an advanced stage in drafting their own social media bans for under-16s. The bloc wants to avoid different rules in different countries and will introduce a blanket age limit to "harmonize" the approaches, officials said.

The bottom line: Several key aspects of the EU proposal remain unclear, such as whether Brussels will set an EU-wide age or let countries set their own. But with officials working on it over the summer ahead of von der Leyen's State of the European Union speech in September, it could soon be time-out for kids on social media.

BIG AND BREAKING

ISRAEL SANCTIONS: EU foreign ministers will on Monday discuss the options for restricting trade with illegal Israeli settlements in the West Bank. "For once, things are moving in the right direction, and we welcome that," Belgium's Foreign Minister Maxime Prévot told POLITICO. "We now encourage the Commission to take the next step: to turn the ideas discussed into concrete proposals."

Leaky boat: Commission Chief Spokesperson Paula Pinho expressed outrage over the fact the options paper on Israel leaked to the media. "It's unacceptable. We have launched an internal investigation. We expect Council will do the same," she told Playbook.

GREEN SHOWDOWN: The EU's flagship decarbonization program is at the heart of a battle between capitals next week — with Sweden's Europe Minister Jessica Rosencrantz telling POLITICO she will fight tooth and claw to keep the rules from being watered down.

RED TAPE FURY: European businesses are unhappy with Brussels' plans to cut bureaucracy and make it easier for companies to operate, warning the bloc is taking too long and doing too little to simplify its

laws.

MONEY MATTERS

NO-DEAL WARNING ON MFF: Europe's wealthier countries would have little to lose by simply walking away from difficult negotiations on the EU's long-term budget, a senior government official from a net contributor nation told Nicholas Vinocur.

Walking away? EU countries are locked in tense talks over the union's nearly €2 trillion seven-year budget, the Multiannual Financial Framework, which would last from 2028-2034. The warning of a possible no-deal scenario raises the stakes further, hinting that net payers may be willing to significantly harden their stance to keep the overall amount down.

Just saying: "Everybody would lose in a no-deal scenario," said the senior official from a significant net payer nation, who was granted anonymity to speak frankly about closed-door negotiations. "But one of the oddities of these negotiations, that the net recipients haven't realized yet, is that for the net contributors, a world without an MFF is by far the least costly option."

"In a no-agreement scenario, net contributors would pay between €500 and €600 billion less than compared to the Commission's proposal," the official added.

Come again? If net contributor and net recipient countries fail to agree on a deal, the ceiling, or maximum amount for the final year of the current MFF, would be carried over in 2028. Without adjustment for inflation, this would come to about €1.4 trillion.

Cohesion in crosshairs: Payments for agricultural subsidies, administrative costs, humanitarian aid, security and foreign policy are all legally protected. But other programs, such as the cohesion policies that many net recipients rely on, would expire. An extension needs a qualified majority in the Council and the net contributors have a blocking minority.

The bottom line: MFF negotiations are quickly moving to a more combative phase, with one telling the other: just dare us. Stay tuned for more.

HAPPENING TODAY: EU ministers in charge of competitiveness are in Ireland, where they'll sit down for talks today on how to support financing of small businesses and industrial decarbonization. My colleague Jacob Parry is on the ground.

Protectionism alert: Irish Enterprise Minister Peter Burke told POLITICO that the Irish presidency is "trying to find strands of commonality" on a Buy European framework. But warns: "I've learned that the very hard way as an open economy... [what] protectionism got us." Competitiveness ministers, he said, are "restless" for solutions to protect their industry.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The International Olympic Committee's decision to provisionally lift the ban on Russian athletes, which could pave the way for them to compete in the 2028 Games in Los Angeles, has led to outrage and even calls for the EU to stop funding the IOC. But does the EU fund the Olympics? Not directly — most of the cash for the games comes from broadcasting rights and sponsorship. But the IOC and other Olympic

bodies can receive grants for specific projects from EU programs such as Erasmus+.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

FAILING THE TEST

PSYCHOMETRIC, QU'EST-CE QUE C'EST? Officials hoping to secure a senior AD7-level post with the European Commission were required to sit a psychometric test. Now, furious staff think the whole thing was botched.

Lost in translation: The test was provided by British-based company SHL and was designed to screen officials' reasoning and other skills. But a Commission official said it wasn't properly translated into French and German, or appeared to be have been translated with AI. "Many people are upset," the official said, adding that practice tests were only available in English, something that may have harmed the chances of non-native English speakers to familiarize themselves with the test.

A second official said that "many candidates" complained about the exam.

Above board: Commission spokesperson Balazs Ujvari told Playbook that SHL confirmed it had used professional translators for all tests, with native-speaking experts reviewing them. The English-only practice test was simply there to familiarize candidates with the platform and "had no bearing" on the results. Some candidates sought clarification after the test, the spokesperson acknowledged, but were told exactly that.

SHL didn't respond to POLITICO's request for comment.

Non-EU outsourcing: The first official slammed the optics of the Commission outsourcing the exam to the U.K. "You cannot just outsource your competition to be an EU official to a British private company," the exasperated official said.

Simply the best: Ujvari said the EU executive surveyed the market in late 2024 and early 2025, before selecting SHL. The Commission concluded the company offered, among the other testing platform providers, the best combination of quality, flexibility and value for money.

Psychometric expansion: The AD7 competition marked the first time the Commission has used psychometric screening in an internal competition, as part of what the executive describes as a pilot to modernize recruitment and promotion procedures. EU officials told Playbook at the time that if the experiment proved successful, the approach could be expanded to other competitions — including future AD5 selection procedures for candidates seeking to join the EU public service.

****What should we expect from this year's Mansion House speech? Fiona Maxwell, Elliot Gulliver-Needham and Eleanor Myers will preview the key policy announcements, what the City wants to hear and what Rachel Reeves' speech could mean for the future of No. 11. Join us online on Monday at 12 p.m. CEST. Register here .****

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

MEET THE NEW MERZ: Dressed in a sharp suit and dark sunglasses, black leather briefcase in hand, Chancellor Friedrich Merz is presenting himself as a hard-charging Reformkanzler — a "chancellor of

reforms” — who can see off the far right.

FOOTBALL UNITY: There’s nothing like a World Cup match to bring together feuding French politicians. Les Bleus’ 2-0 win over Morocco led to a rare moment of détente .

WRAP IT UP: The EU has kicked off its squeeze on allegedly unfair Chinese trade practices by opening an investigation into cheap imports of Pekin duck, after other sellers said they couldn’t compete on price. But what will be the size of the bill … ? Read about it in Morning Trade.

RUE DU MUR? MAUERSTRASSE? VIA DEL MURO? European stock exchanges are battling Wall Street banks to be at the center of global financial trading .

SUMMER BLOCKBUSTER: In this week’s Declassified , Paul Dallison looks at the movie hit of the year, based on the travails of Marine Le Pen and Nigel Farage.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mainly sunny, top of 30C.

RED DEVILS OR LA ROJA: Belgium and Spain face off tonight in the World Cup quarterfinals, with kickoff scheduled for 9 p.m. local time. But where should you watch the match?

Jupiler Fan Village: Hardcore Belgium fans will find few places better than the team’s dedicated viewing complex in Uccle’s Wolvendael Park. Your viewing experience will be enhanced by food trucks, outdoor bars and DJ sets. Organizers advise supporters to arrive early and to travel by public transport to beat the queues.

Le Schmet: Just off Louise, this trendy bar has been streaming all Belgium games and became a fan favorite during the last game for handing out free fries to anyone wearing the national team’s shirt.

Café la Pompe: Supporting the Spanish? Saint Gilles has a large Iberian community and this outdoor cervezaria is a great spot for fans of all stripes to watch matches. There’s even a Spanish supermarket around the corner if you want to stock up on Rioja and jamon for half time.

CoHop: Brussels’ cooperative brewpub comes recommended by Spanish diplomats as the place to watch the game this weekend with a sympathetic crowd, with beer, cheese and Belgian saucisson (sorry, no botifarra).

AFRICAN EXTRAVAGANZA: Brussels AfroDisiac festival of African and Afro-Caribbean cultures is back in the Bois de la Cambre this Saturday and Sunday, with street food, live music, workshops and family activities on offer.

MORE ON IRISH MEETING: Playbook reported earlier this week about the first informal ministerial meeting of the Irish EU presidency and how the number of high-level attendees was low. The presidency told us two non-EU heavyweights — Ukraine and Moldova — were represented by their social affairs ministers, and that all 27 EU countries were represented … by officials.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz is hoping to wrap up his health care reform but faces an unpredictable day in the Bundesrat.

London: Nigel Farage's election campaign against the enigmatic Count Binface has been rocked by revelations of a criminal probe into a political donation.

Paris: Socialist Party leader Olivier Faure suffered a rare internal defeat as party members backed a closed primary for the 2027 presidential contest , handing a boost to his rivals.

Washington PM: Republicans want to move on from the unpopular Middle East war before the midterms — but Iran and Donald Trump are making that difficult.

AGENDA

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen receives Eurogroup president Kyriakos Pierrakakis.

— Coreper II meets at 3 p.m.

— The Economic and Financial Affairs Council meets in Brussels, with Financial Services Commissioner Maria Luís Albuquerque and Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis attending. Press conference at 2:00 p.m. Watch .

— EU competition ministers hold an informal meeting in Dublin at 10:30 a.m., with a press conference following at 4:15 p.m. Watch .

— Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos meets Montenegrin Prime Minister Miloško Spajić and Andrija Mandić, speaker of the Montenegrin parliament.

— Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin meets with European Investment Bank President Nadia Calviño.

BIRTHDAYS

Permanent Representative of Poland to the EU Agnieszka Bartol; Igor Mally, sherpa of former Slovenian PM Robert Golob; Isabelle Vereecken, from the European Data Protection Board Secretariat (and a Brussels Power 40 alum); Robin Hörrmann from Booking.com; Prokopis Pavlopoulos, former president of Greece; European Parliament's Axel Heyer.

Celebrating Saturday: MEP Nikolina Brnjac; former MEPs Marco Zanni and Sergio Gutiérrez Prieto, who is now a member of Spain's Congress of Deputies; European Parliament's Henrik Kjellin; European Commission's Sophie Müller; Mont Blanc Circle's Erik Jonnaert; FIPRA's Peter Tulkens. Day of the Flemish Community of Belgium; International Day of Reflection and Commemoration of the 1995 Genocide in Srebrenica.

Celebrating Sunday: MEPs Lukas Mandl and Martin Schirdewan; former MEPs Eider Gardiazabal Rubial, Mercedes Bresso and Simona Bonafè; Bloomberg's Zosia Wanat, a POLITICO alumna; EUIPO's Ewa Lekan; European Commission's Carl-Christian Buhr; Irina Bokova, former director-general of UNESCO; Friends of Europe's Nathalie Furrer; activist and Nobel Prize laureate Malala Yousafzai.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from OpenAI: AI is opening up new opportunities for learning, discovery and creativity, including for young people. Our responsibility is to help them benefit from these tools in ways that are age-appropriate and support their development. In ChatGPT, teen accounts have added safeguards designed to reduce harmful or age-inappropriate content. We also believe parents should have easy-to-use tools to guide how AI works for their family. Parental controls in ChatGPT let families link parent and teen accounts and shape an experience that works for them, with settings for quiet hours, memory and image generation, plus safety notifications in limited situations involving serious safety concerns. This approach reflects our European Youth Safety Blueprint : young people should be empowered to use AI confidently and safely, with protections that support their wellbeing.****

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